

▲ TOURISM: DESTINATION SOUTH

"Only about 30 per cent foreign tourists travel to south India...a tourism council can be created with the southern states. However, with 18.8 million arrivals in 2022, domestic tourism is booming in Kerala"

K.S. SRINIVAS
Principal Secretary, Kerala Tourism

BANDEEP SINGH



"Our education system lacks quality and does not recognise the dreams and creative voice of youth. That's why so many migrate to foreign lands"

FATHIMA THAHILIYA
Activist and youth leader

▼ ENVIRONMENT: MINIMISING MAN-ANIMAL CONFLICT



"Man-animal conflict is a complex issue. I think the deep bonds between indigenous people and wildlife have been grossly underappreciated"

RAMAN SUKUMAR
National Science Chair, Centre for Ecological Sciences, IISc

"In my opinion, we don't have suitable habitat for the cheetah. Kuno is partly hilly and has only one prey. The temperature in summers is very high too"

A.J.T. JOHNSINGH
Scientific Advisor, WWF India and The Corbett Foundation

and the "Constitution" of India. The success of the controversial film *The Kerala Story*, based on religious conversions, also became a point of discussion. "It is completely false," said CPI(M) leader Dr Chintha Jerome. "Love, resilience and secularism is the simple motto of Kerala," she said. Filmmaker Bina Paul, also the former artistic director of the International Film Festival of Kerala, noted how Keralites themselves shunned the movie in favour of *2018*, which is now the highest-grossing Malayalam film so far. For Paul, it is *2018* that really tells Kerala's story, documenting how people came together in the rescue efforts against the devastating floods of the year.

Kerala's rich culture was in full display at the conclave. Padma Shri-honoured chenda artist Peruvanam Kuttan Marar and his ensemble delighted audiences, while playback singer-actor Vijay Yesudas rendered a few tunes, including a Hindi track sung by his father K.J. Yesudas, 'Jab Deep Jale Aana'. The highlight was a colourful medley that saw Mohiniattam and Kathakali dancers, Theyyam artists and Kalaripayattu practitioners coming together to showcase the vibrant performing art traditions of the state. ■

by Suhani Singh